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We got the original "Resident Evil" films all wrong

In the sixth and final installment of [Paul W.S. Anderson's](#) original "[Resident Evil](#)" film franchise, the writer-director — known for his abrasive, nu-metal vulgar auteurism — raises a middle finger of sorts to his detractors. Over 17 years and thousands of poor reviews, Anderson's adaptations of the beloved Capcom survival-horror [video game](#) series became somewhat famous for pissing off critics and diehard game fans alike. The bulk of Anderson's sprawling vision chose to forgo the games' shadowy zombie story for high-octane thrills and compelling (if clunky) commentary on corporate greed, biological warfare, [AI](#) and identity. His "Resident Evil" films are unapologetically ambitious and undeniably imperfect, much like their human lead, Alice ([Milla Jovovich](#)), whose sole mission is to retain her humanity in a world eating itself alive. In charmingly symbiotic fashion, neither Alice nor Anderson himself is willing to give up on their mission without a fight.

As if Anderson were taking a victory lap to celebrate the impressive feat of making six films in a series that was horribly reviewed but terribly financially successful, a flashback sequence in 2016's "Resident Evil: The Final Chapter" closes the sextet's loop. In the scene, set just before the events of 2002's "[Resident Evil](#)," executives at the diabolical Umbrella Corporation gather to discuss the world's impending end. Nuclear war is a real possibility, climate change is inevitable, famine and death are on the horizon. Umbrella's answer? The T-Virus, a mutagenic pathogen that will bring an undead plague across the Earth, leaving it free for Umbrella's higher-ups and other wealthy patrons to inhabit once the zombies are safely eradicated. "We will emerge onto a cleansed Earth," says Umbrella CEO Dr. Isaacs (Iain Glen), "one that we can then reboot in our image."



Everything has become so hyper-personalized and algorithmic that viewers subconsciously watch media looking for themselves. But that is the great joy of Anderson's "Resident Evil" films: They are so remarkably stylized, so absurdly over-the-top, so referential and deferent to Anderson's own inspirations, that they've become singular visions.

Here, Anderson's message is clear: Whoever has the power controls the image. And if one doesn't like that image, they're free to fight back. But to know what they're fighting for, one must first understand what they're fighting against, engaging with the enemy rather than dismissing it.

That idea has been rattling around my mind after seeing [Zach Cregger's](#) new "Resident Evil," itself a reboot made in its creator's image. Cregger's film is more faithful to the spirit of the original games, with uncertainty and plenty of monsters just around every dark corner. The movie trades the gun-slinging Umbrella defector Alice for a medical courier named Bryan (Austin Abrams), who finds himself completely out of his depth when a routine delivery mutates into something much more horrifying.

"I'd rather watch a movie starring a schlub who's out of shape and never fired a gun before," Cregger [told](#) Polygon of his adaptation. Unlike Alice, Bryan is the audience stand-in: the average guy who responds to a mind-boggling, impossible situation as clumsily as you or I might. Critics and audiences responded in turn, taking an immediate shine to Bryan's doofiness and contrasting it with Alice's purposeful, goal-oriented approach to a zombie apocalypse. One review [called](#) Cregger's movie "different and much better than the other 'Resident Evil' movies," which were termed "depersonalized zombie sludge."

I find that to be the trouble with the way people watch and talk about films these days, as if a movie's merit is defined by whether or not it reflects the viewer. Everything has become so hyper-personalized and algorithmic that viewers subconsciously watch media looking for themselves. The line between art and commerce has blurred so much that people unintentionally conflate all visual media with advertising — if they can't see themselves in it, they're not buying it.

But that is the great joy of Anderson's "Resident Evil" films: They are so remarkably stylized, so absurdly over-the-top, so referential and deferent to Anderson's own inspirations, that they've become singular visions. The mere fact that there are six increasingly wacky installments should be enough to warrant curiosity. And yet, Anderson's "Resident Evil" has always been the butt of the joke, brushed off largely because his movies dared to be different when people wanted more of the same.

Perhaps that's rich, given just how much DNA the original "Resident Evil" franchise shares with the "[Matrix](#)," "[Mad Max](#)," and "[Alien](#)" franchises. And I'm no fool; having seen all of Anderson's "Resident Evil" films, I know they are not created equal. Some, like the fifth installment, "Retribution" — which reorients the series to a much more salient, focused place — stand head and shoulders above others. But not every "Matrix," "Alien," "Mad Max," or other film franchise movie shares the same quality as its in-universe peers, either. While one might argue that those are original titles of distinguished quality, it's unfair to write off "Resident Evil" simply because it's a game adaptation. After all, Anderson's most fascinating ideas merge the immersive structure of gaming with the spectacle of filmmaking, and he's one of the few filmmakers who has successfully pulled off such an audacious combination.

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From the start, Alice is the viewer's avatar, at once a skilled security operative and someone with no memory of their past. She, much like the person behind the proverbial controller, is dropped into a world quickly becoming overrun by a viral plague with no idea what to do. Press A to jump. Press X to shoot. Press Y+X for the combo move. Because we learn alongside Alice — only watching instead of playing — Anderson forges a connection between the viewer and the character on screen without running the analog cable that connects a controller to a console, as Cregger seems keen to do. Anderson's "Resident Evil" protagonist is not a projection of any specific viewer. Rather, she's the film's embodiment of a lawful good, pre-programmed to fulfill her mission linearly without getting lost in the big, open world.

Vulgar auteurism doesn't necessarily suggest that a film is as "good" as others of its ilk, only that the film earnestly explores ideas as enduring as those in any formally rigid, awards-bait film. Anderson's "Resident Evil" franchise — with all of its ruminations on identity in the tech age, artificially intelligent warfare, corruption and greed — certainly fits that bill.

Maybe that can feel stifling for some viewers. Across six films, Alice rarely faces a challenge that she can't overcome. Even the endings feel like save points, with Alice respawning at the start of each consecutive movie with another mutated monkey on her back.

For me, that's where Anderson's series gets its draw. Alice is placed in an impossible situation with no say in the matter, and no choice but to fight her way out. As she progresses through the level-by-level (or, in this case, film-by-film) structure, the knowledge she acquires informs her identity and reorients her spirit. Alice's humanity is defined by her total rejection of the manufactured digital world and the havoc its creators wrought. Her quest is not to defeat all of the monsters, but to always remember that every zombie was, like her, human. That's how she holds onto her soul.

But no matter how noble Alice's mission is, her consistent character is no match for Anderson's heavy hand. His "Resident Evil" films are as gratuitous as they are ridiculous — often repetitive and typically predictable. I've never found that to be a barrier to entry, especially for something so balls-to-the-wall exciting as these movies. The merits of so-called vulgar auteurism are often debated among film fans. But to say that no filmmakers are working in mainstream, high-flying, big-budget action with real artistic value negates the principle of filmmaking as an art form. Just because something doesn't fit into the regressive limitations of "good" and "bad" doesn't mean that it has no worth. Assertions of vulgar auteurism don't necessarily suggest that a film is as "good" as others of its ilk, only that the film earnestly explores ideas as enduring as those in any formally rigid, awards-bait film. Anderson's "Resident Evil" franchise — with all of its ruminations on identity in the tech age, artificially intelligent warfare, corruption and greed — certainly fits that bill.

I find that I'm beating this drum daily, trying to convince people that thoughtfully engaging with art they don't immediately like or understand is a worthwhile practice. But we've reached a moment in media consumption where reputation is practically insurmountable. It's become more difficult to convince people of "bad" media's merits, to encourage them to see with eyes other than their own. I stumble into these moments all the time, waxing poetic about misunderstood and misread films like Halle Berry's "Catwoman," or claiming Zack Snyder's "[Sucker Punch](#)" is a bold feminist text and not 110 minutes of CGI-laden misogyny. In all my years of picking apart films to grasp why they appeal to my senses, I've watched others' curiosity decline, especially in the face of someone else's passion. Now that Cregger's "Resident Evil" looks and feels a bit more like the classic games, I

fear the effusive reaction will drown out Anderson's franchise's nutty strengths forever.

Of course, not everything has to be highbrow and meaningful. Some things are silly, and will be just fine remaining that way. But it's the inclination to bang the gavel and move on that irks me. With AI images bleeding into the real world at a pace none of us can keep up with, there's human marvel to behold in Anderson's madness. These are films of strenuous work and daring vision, even when their execution doesn't always match up with those big ideas. Analyzing what works and what doesn't, instead of dismissing the whole thing outright, is a free and life-affirming way to connect with the world and its people. Investigating everything further — following Alice down the rabbit hole and fighting alongside her to preserve what makes us human — might be laborious at times, sure. But it just might be one of the last ways to save our souls.

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